

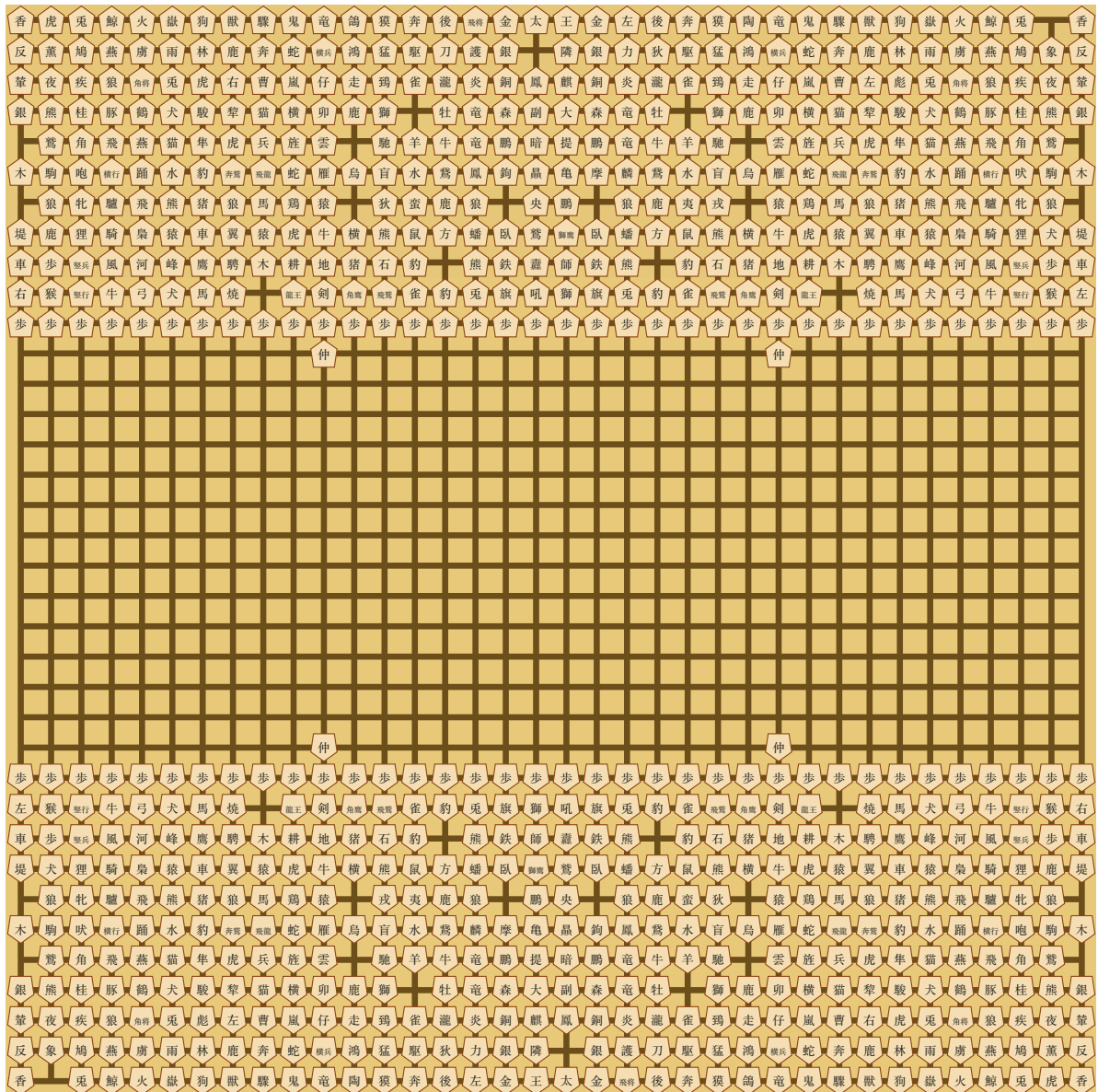
SHOGI · VARIANT 21 OF 24

# Taikyoku Shogi

**36×36**  
BOARD

**2**  
PLAYERS

# TAIKYOKU SHOGI



Taikyoku Shogi — starting position

<https://engine.moddable.games/play/?game=shogi&variant=taikyoku-shogi>

Taikyoku Shogi ( , *Ultimate Chess*) is the largest chess variant ever documented. Played on a 36×36 board with 402 piece types per side (804 pieces total) on 1,296 squares, it is documented in a single known Japanese manuscript held at Osaka Municipal Central Library. Whether the game was ever actually played to completion is disputed — a single game would require an estimated 10,000+ moves. The transcription used here is by L. Lynn Smith.

## THE BOARD

36×36 grid (1,296 squares). Standard Shogi orientation. Each player occupies the first 12 ranks from their side (Sente: ranks 1–12; Gote: ranks 25–36). Ranks 13–24 are empty at the start.

## ROYALS

- ♦ **King** (does not promote) — royal
- ♦ **Crown Prince** (promotes to King) — royal once promoted

Win: capture both the opponent's King and Crown Prince (or their only royal if the Crown Prince has not promoted).

## PIECE LIST

All 402 pieces per side, with count and promoted form:

| PIECE             | QTY | PROMOTES TO          |
|-------------------|-----|----------------------|
| King              | 1   | — (does not promote) |
| Crown Prince      | 1   | King                 |
| Gold General      | 2   | Rook                 |
| Right General     | 1   | Right Army           |
| Left General      | 1   | Left Army            |
| Rear Standard     | 2   | Center Standard      |
| Free King         | 2   | Great General        |
| Free Tapir        | 2   | Free King            |
| Wooden Dove       | 1   | —                    |
| Ceramic Dove      | 1   | —                    |
| Earth Dragon      | 2   | Rain Dragon          |
| Free Demon        | 2   | Free King            |
| Running Horse     | 2   | Free Demon           |
| Beast Cadet       | 2   | Beast Officer        |
| Long-Nosed Goblin | 2   | —                    |
| Mountain Eagle    | 2   | Soaring Eagle        |
| Fire Demon        | 2   | Free Fire            |
| Whale             | 2   | Great Whale          |
| Running Rabbit    | 2   | Treacherous Fox      |
| White Tiger       | 1   | Divine Tiger         |
| Turtle Snake      | 1   | Divine Turtle        |
| Lance             | 2   | White Horse          |
| Reverse Chariot   | 2   | Whale                |
| Fragrant Elephant | 1   | Elephant King        |
| White Elephant    | 1   | Elephant King        |
| Mountain Dove     | 2   | Great Dove           |
| Flying Swallow    | 2   | Rook                 |
| Captive Officer   | 2   | Captive Bird         |
| Rain Dragon       | 2   | Great Dragon         |
| Forest Demon      | 2   | Thunder Runner       |

Total: 402 pieces per side.

### STARTING POSITION (SENTE)

Positions are given as (rank, column). Columns 1–36 run left to right; rank 1 is Sente’s back rank. Gote’s setup is the mirror: rank 36 = Gote’s back rank, column positions reversed.

| RANK | PIECES AND COLUMNS                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
|------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1    | Lance (1,36), Reverse Chariot (2,35), White Elephant (3 — singular), FrAGRant Elephant (34), Mountain Dove (4,33), Flying Swallow (5,32), Captive Officer (6,31), Rain Dragon (7,30), Forest Demon (8,29), Mountain Stag (9,28), Running Pup (10,27), Running Serpent (11,26), Side Serpent (12,25), Great Dove (13,24), Running Tiger (14,23), Running Bear (15,22), Night Sword (16), Rear Standard (17,20), <b>King (18), Crown Prince (19)</b> , Gold General (17,20 shared), Right General (21), Left General (16 — overlaps Night Sword?), Wrestler (16)... |

*Note: The original manuscript gives setup positions by rank and column number. Rank 1 holds the outermost defensive pieces; Ranks 2–10 hold the remaining armies; Rank 11 holds all 36 Pawns; Rank 12 holds Dogs (columns 6, 15, 22, 31) and Go-Betweens (columns 11, 26).*

For the authoritative column-by-column starting position, consult [chessvariants.com/shogivariants.dir/taikyoku\\_english.html](https://chessvariants.com/shogivariants.dir/taikyoku_english.html).

### PIECE RANKING (FOR JUMP CAPTURES)

The following pieces can jump over lower-ranked pieces to make captures (as in Tenjiku Shogi):

| RANK           | PIECES                                                         |
|----------------|----------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1 (highest)    | King, Crown Prince                                             |
| 2              | Great General                                                  |
| 3              | Vice General                                                   |
| 4              | Bishop General, Rook General, Violent Dragon, Flying Crocodile |
| 5 (all others) | All remaining pieces                                           |

A piece of rank R can jump over any number of pieces ranked 5 (the rank below R), continuing until making a capture.

### PROMOTION

- ♦ Pieces promote upon reaching any of the **opponent’s 11 ranks** (ranks 26–36 for Sente)
- ♦ Captured pieces are permanently removed from play (no drops)
- ♦ Each piece promotes to its fixed promoted form (listed in the piece table above)
- ♦ Promotion is irreversible

## **HISTORICAL NOTE**

Taikyoku Shogi is documented in a manuscript held at Osaka Municipal Central Library. Its playability has been questioned by historians — some believe it was a theoretical exercise assembled by combining all known Shogi variants rather than a game designed for practical play. No game records from historical times have survived, and no mating problems have been published.

## **ATTRIBUTION**

Taikyoku Shogi is documented in a single known Japanese manuscript. English transcription by L. Lynn Smith, with thanks to Patrick Davin. Source: [chessvariants.com/shogivariants.dir/taikyoku\\_english.html](https://chessvariants.com/shogivariants.dir/taikyoku_english.html)